that Nicaragua was becoming a base camp for Communizing all of Central America.

Nicaragua's Sandinista government had taken power in 1979, after the overthrow of dictator Anastasio Somoza, with pledges to the Nicaraguan people and the Organization of American States that it would replace Somoza's dictatorship with democracy. It promised free elections, a free press, free enterprise, and an independent judiciary. But within weeks of Somoza's overthrow, the Sandinistas had begun replacing one dictatorship with another: They seized television and radio stations and began censoring newspapers and crushing whatever democratic sentiment they encountered as violently and ruthlessly as Somoza had ever done. Meanwhile they allied themselves with Castro, Moscow, and the Eastern bloc.

Once they were in power, the Sandinistas began trying to export their Marxist revolution to neighboring El Salvador and other countries in Central America. They proved themselves masters at propaganda, peddling an image of themselves in Europe and America as kindly men whose democratic reforms were being thwarted by the Great Colossus of the North—us.

Early in my first year in the White House, we launched an initiative aimed at helping Caribbean and Central American countries reverse the great economic and social inequities that made many of them ripe for subversion and revolution. But it was soon apparent it was going to take more than that to stop the Marxist guerrillas financed by Castro and Brezhnev. And while our friends in Mexico and Venezuela had indicated that they would join us in a collaborative effort to resist the advance of Marxism in Latin America, it was becoming apparent that they weren't ready to make the kind of commitment necessary to do the job. The United States would have to meet the challenge largely alone—but